



GUIDE

to the

National Merit® Scholarship Program



September 2025

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GUIDE
to the
NATIONAL MERIT® SCHOLARSHIP PROGRAM



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Introduction

The National Merit® Scholarship Program, conducted by National Merit Scholarship Corporation (NMSC®), is an annual academic competition for recognition and college undergraduate scholarships. Established in 1955, NMSC is a privately financed not-for-profit organization that operates without government assistance.

The competition is open to all U.S. high school students who meet published participation requirements. Scholarship winners are chosen on the basis of their abilities, skills, and accomplishments—without regard to gender, race, ethnic origin, or religious preference.

The goals of the National Merit Scholarship Program are to:

- *identify and honor academically talented U.S. high school students and encourage them to pursue rigorous college studies;*
- *provide professional services for corporations, company foundations, colleges and universities, and other individuals and organizations that wish to sponsor scholarships for outstanding participants in the competition;*
- *promote a broader and deeper respect for learning in general and for exceptionally talented individuals in particular;*
- *stimulate increased support for the education of scholastically able students; and*
- *encourage the pursuit of academic excellence at all levels of education.*

Although a sizable number of National Merit Scholarships are underwritten by NMSC with its own funds, the majority of scholarships awarded in the National Merit Program are sponsored by about 300 corporate organizations and higher education institutions. Since

the first scholarships were awarded in 1956, the educational opportunities of hundreds of thousands of academically talented young people have been enhanced by the support of scholarship sponsors, such as those listed on pages 32–40.

Each year, educators in about 20,000 high schools provide the opportunity for their students to participate in the National Merit Scholarship Program. The cooperation and assistance of these principals and counselors are essential to the successful operation of the competition, and NMSC is sincerely grateful to them.

This *Guide* is updated and distributed annually as a reference for school administrators. NMSC welcomes suggestions for improving this distribution and all other program materials provided for schools and students.

Student participation and recognition

Currently, over 1.3 million students in about 20,000 high schools enter the National Merit® Scholarship Program each year. Some 50,000 entrants qualify for program recognition, and approximately 7,590 outstanding students receive scholarships for college undergraduate study. The awards, valued at over \$33 million, are underwritten by NMSC® with its own funds, by several hundred corporate organizations and higher education institutions, and by individual donors.

Program entry

Students enter the National Merit Program by taking the Preliminary SAT/National Merit Scholarship Qualifying Test (PSAT/NMSQT®) and meeting other program entry requirements (listed on pages 6–8). The test, administered annually in the fall, is cosponsored by NMSC and College Board. (Information about test registration and procedures is on pages 41–46.) Questions regarding the test should be directed to College Board. All inquiries about the National Merit Program should be directed to NMSC, which independently conducts the competition.

NMSC uses the PSAT/NMSQT as an initial screen of the large number of entrants to the program. A particular year's test is the entry vehicle for a specific year's competition. For example, the 2024 PSAT/NMSQT was used for entry to the 2026 National Merit Program. Most 2026 program participants will enter college in the fall of 2026. The announcement of Semifinalists in September 2025 marks the midpoint of the 2026 competition; it will conclude in the spring of 2026 when winners of National Merit Scholarships are notified and their names are released to news media. The 2027 program begins with the PSAT/NMSQT administration in the fall of 2025 and ends in the spring of 2027. Each competition spans about one and a half years.

To ensure that the competition is conducted in a timely manner and that all participants are treated consistently, NMSC adheres to specified program requirements and deadlines. A schedule of key dates for both the 2026 and 2027 competitions is on pages 47–49.

Over 70 years, the National Merit Scholarship Program has recognized more than 3.4 million high school students for their exceptional scholastic potential and about 455,000 have received over \$1.8 billion in college scholarships. The entry requirements include taking the PSAT/NMSQT in the specified year of the high school program, which is the junior year for students who will spend the usual four years in grades 9 through 12.



Information for students who wish to enter the competition is provided in the *PSAT/NMSQT Student Guide*, which is available on College Board's website and at www.nationalmerit.org, each fall before the test administration.

Requirements for entry

To participate in the 2026 competition, a student must:

1. be enrolled as a high school student (traditional or home-schooled), progressing normally toward graduation or completion of high school, and planning to enroll full-time in college no later than the fall following completion of high school;
2. take the PSAT/NMSQT in the specified year of the high school program and **no later than** the third year in grades 9 through 12, regardless of grade classification or educational pattern; and
3. attend high school in the United States, District of Columbia, or U.S. commonwealths and territories; or meet the citizenship requirements for students attending high school outside the United States (see box below).

To be eligible for the 2026 National Merit Scholarship Program, a student attending high school outside the United States must be a citizen of the United States; or be a U.S. lawful permanent resident (or have applied for permanent residence, the application for which has not been denied) and intend to become a U.S. citizen at the earliest opportunity allowed by law.

When to take the qualifying test

Because a student can participate (and be considered for a scholarship) in only one specific program year, the year in which the student takes the PSAT/NMSQT to enter the competition is very important. The test must be taken in the specified year of the student's high school program, as described below.

1. **Students who plan to spend the usual four years in high school (grades 9 through 12) before entering college full-time** must

take the PSAT/NMSQT in their third year (usually grade 11, junior year). They will be entering the competition that ends when awards are offered in the spring of their fourth high school year (usually grade 12, senior year), the same year they will leave high school and enter college.

Some schools encourage their **sophomore** students to take the PSAT/NMSQT for guidance purposes; however, if these students are spending four years in grades 9 through 12, they must take the test again when they are juniors to enter the National Merit Scholarship Program.

2. **Students who plan to leave high school early to enroll in college full-time after spending three years or less in grades 9 through 12** usually can participate in the National Merit Program if they take the PSAT/NMSQT before they enroll in college. Such students must take the PSAT/NMSQT in either the next-to-last year or the last year they are enrolled in high school.
 - a) Those who take the PSAT/NMSQT in the *next-to-last year* of high school will be entering the competition for awards to be offered as they are finishing their final high school year.
 - b) Those who take the PSAT/NMSQT in their *last year* of high school will be entering the competition for awards to be offered the year after they have completed high school.
3. **Students who are dual enrolled in both high school and college** must take the PSAT/NMSQT in the fall of their third year of high school (grade 11, junior year) to enter the National Merit Program. The high school determines whether a student is dual enrolled and confirms the student's status as a high school student.
4. **Students who plan to spend five years in grades 9 through 12** usually can participate in the National Merit Program if they take the PSAT/NMSQT in both the third and fourth years of high school. A five-year student will not be eligible for the program until a written request for entry to the competition is approved by NMSC. The request should identify the student's name, high

school, and specific educational pattern (including the academic years spent in grades 9 through 12).

The student's highest possible level of recognition is determined by the qualifying score earned during the third year, the year in which all other competitors are considered. The student must qualify at or above that same level in the fourth year in order to compete in the fifth year, the year the student will leave high school and enter college.

Note: If there is a question about whether a student can participate in the National Merit Program because educational plans do not fit one of the previous descriptions, or for any other reason, contact NMSC immediately.

The student's responses to National Merit Scholarship Program eligibility questions provided during exam set-up for the PSAT/NMSQT are used to determine whether the student meets requirements to participate in a particular year's program. (More information about these questions can be found on page 35 in the NMSC section of the 2025 *PSAT/NMSQT Student Guide*.) Score reports provided to test takers and their schools indicate only whether or not the student is a program participant, not whether the student qualifies for recognition. Encourage your students to review this section of the score report carefully. A school official or the student should immediately contact NMSC regarding any error or change that may affect the student's participation in the program.

If a student misses the PSAT/NMSQT administration

A student who does not take the PSAT/NMSQT because of illness, an emergency, or other extenuating circumstance (but meets all other requirements for program participation) may still be able to enter the competition. If the PSAT/NMSQT testing window has not yet closed, the student may be able to take the PSAT/NMSQT on another date or at another school. If the PSAT/NMSQT testing window has closed, the student or a school official must **write** to NMSC to request alternate entry procedures. The alternate entry request should include the student's name and home address, the contact information of the person making the request, the name and address of the

student's high school, and a brief explanation of why the student missed the test. To be considered, a request should be sent as soon as possible but **must be postmarked no later than April 1** following the missed PSAT/NMSQT administration. NMSC will provide the alternate entry form that requires the signature of the high school principal, guidance counselor, or other school official designated by the principal.

Program recognition

The PSAT/NMSQT is administered in a digital format in October. Students will receive a Reading and Writing section score and a Math section score. NMSC will compute the 2025 NMSC Selection Index scores by doubling the Reading and Writing section score, adding the Math section score, and dividing the total by 10. Score levels sufficient for recognition vary from year to year and from state to state; those for the 2026 competition are given on pages 13–14.

High scorers

In the spring following the PSAT/NMSQT administration, NMSC identifies about 50,000 program participants with the highest PSAT/NMSQT Selection Index scores and contacts their high school principals, asking them to identify any errors or changes in the reported eligibility of their high scorers. It is not until the beginning of the next school year that NMSC notifies high scorers that they have qualified as either Semifinalists or Commended Students.

Semifinalists

More than 16,000 of the high scorers, representing less than 1 percent of the nation's high school graduating seniors, qualify as Semifinalists in each annual National Merit Program. They are the only participants who have an opportunity to advance in the competition for some 6,930 Merit Scholarship® awards.

To ensure that academically talented students from all parts of the U.S. are included in this talent pool, Semifinalists are named on a state-representational basis. A participant can be considered

for Semifinalist standing in only one state or other selection unit (explained below), based on the high school in which the student is regularly enrolled when the PSAT/NMSQT is taken to enter the competition.

Using the most recent data available, NMSC determines an allocation of Semifinalists for each of the 50 states, based on the state's percentage of the national total of graduating high school seniors. For example, the Semifinalist allocation for a state that enrolls approximately 2 percent of the nation's high school graduates would be about 320 (2 percent of the 16,000 Semifinalists).

To begin the process of establishing each state's Semifinalist qualifying score, the Selection Index scores of all students in the state who meet program entry requirements are arranged in descending order. The score at which the state's allocation is most closely filled becomes the Semifinalist qualifying score for that state. Entrants with a Selection Index score at or above the qualifying score are named Semifinalists. The scores of all Semifinalists are extremely high. Although this process results in qualifying scores that vary from one state to another and from year to year, it produces an equitable, representative distribution of recognized students nationwide.

In addition to Semifinalists designated in each of the 50 states, and without affecting the allocation to any state, Semifinalists are named in several other selection units that NMSC has established for the competition. These additional units are for participants attending schools in the District of Columbia, schools in U.S. commonwealths and territories, schools in other countries that enroll U.S. citizens, and U.S. boarding schools that enroll a sizable proportion of their students from outside the state in which the school is located. Boarding schools are grouped into geographic regions, each consisting of several states; the Semifinalist qualifying score for students in each region is the same as the highest qualifying score among the states within that region.

In September, NMSC sends principals of participating high schools a booklet listing the names of the 16,000 Semifinalists by state and high school. Principals of schools enrolling Semifinalists are also sent scholarship application information and instructions for the students and school. NMSC sends the names of Semifinalists to news media for announcement and to regionally accredited four-

National Merit Scholarship Corporation (NMSC) recognizes the pivotal role of high school officials and the essential part they play in the development of academic talent. An Advisory Council of experienced educational professionals from throughout the United States meets with NMSC's management each year to review the effectiveness of program procedures and materials and consider suggestions for improvement.



year U.S. colleges and universities in an effort to enhance the educational opportunities of these scholastically talented young people.

Commended Students

About 34,000 of the 50,000 high scorers in each annual National Merit Scholarship Program are named Commended Students based on a national Selection Index qualifying score, applicable to all participants without regard to state-by-state distribution. The qualifying score for this level of recognition varies from year to year. All National Merit Program participants who score at or above the Commended level but below their selection unit's Semifinalist qualifying score are designated Commended Students.

In mid-September, NMSC sends principals a list of their school's Commended Students with *Letters of Commendation* for presentation to the students. Although Commended Students are honored for their academic promise, they do not continue in the competition for National Merit Scholarship awards. Some, however, may be candidates for Special Scholarships offered by corporate sponsors (explained on pages 22–23).

National Merit Program qualifying data for 2026

The National Merit Scholarship Program honors individual students for their exceptional scholastic potential. The program does not measure the quality or effectiveness of education within a school, district, or state. The table on pages 13–14 relates only to the 2026 National Merit Program, which began with the administration of the 2024 PSAT/NMSQT. **This information is provided as a reference for principals and counselors who understand the design and purpose of the National Merit Scholarship Program and the limited usefulness of the data.**

A number of factors should be kept in mind when interpreting data in the table. First, since Semifinalists are named on a state-representational basis, qualifying scores required for Semifinalist standing vary from one state to another. This ensures that students from all parts of the nation are included in the Semifinalist talent pool. The soundness of this method has been confirmed by

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2026 National Merit Scholarship Program

Semifinalists and Commended Students—2024 PSAT/NMSQT*

	<i>Selection Index Qualifying Score</i>	SEMIFINALISTS		COMMENDED STUDENTS**	
		<i>Number</i>	<i>Number of Schools</i>	<i>Number</i>	<i>Number of Schools</i>
Alabama	214	228	62	141	57
Alaska	215	31	14	24	16
Arizona	218	409	92	557	114
Arkansas	215	141	44	106	42
California	224	2,172	379	6,840	709
Colorado	219	287	102	579	142
Connecticut	223	193	57	709	131
Delaware	220	47	17	84	24
Florida	219	1,008	271	1,824	379
Georgia	220	620	130	1,243	208
Hawaii	219	60	12	124	32
Idaho	215	90	35	76	34
Illinois	222	748	138	1,888	243
Indiana	218	333	99	531	147
Iowa	214	138	49	77	38
Kansas	216	136	43	113	53
Kentucky	214	200	66	121	54
Louisiana	216	220	63	219	69
Maine	217	57	26	63	37
Maryland	224	348	81	1,290	157
Massachusetts	225	282	88	1,754	223
Michigan	220	470	118	965	206
Minnesota	219	266	74	438	110
Mississippi	213	153	46	53	32
Missouri	217	281	92	326	100
Montana	213	48	26	8	6
Nebraska	214	109	39	63	34
Nevada	214	185	41	78	30
New Hampshire	219	51	27	99	36
New Jersey	225	511	130	3,199	303
New Mexico	210	111	39	0	0

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2026 National Merit Scholarship Program (continued)

Semifinalists and Commended Students—2024 PSAT/NMSQT*

	SEMIFINALISTS			COMMENDED STUDENTS**	
	<i>Selection Index Qualifying Score</i>	<i>Number</i>	<i>Number of Schools</i>	<i>Number</i>	<i>Number of Schools</i>
New York	223	992	219	3,378	456
North Carolina	220	523	109	1,151	207
North Dakota	210	26	11	0	0
Ohio	219	490	145	999	220
Oklahoma	212	214	56	39	23
Oregon	219	188	44	318	76
Pennsylvania	221	612	161	1,511	305
Rhode Island	219	50	16	96	29
South Carolina	215	225	78	197	82
South Dakota	211	46	21	6	4
Tennessee	219	306	83	521	120
Texas	222	1,673	309	4,653	607
Utah	213	199	66	68	35
Vermont	216	27	15	27	19
Virginia	224	489	100	1,912	209
Washington	224	388	78	1,295	164
West Virginia	210	66	31	0	0
Wisconsin	215	287	107	216	104
Wyoming	210	20	12	0	0
District of Columbia	225	37	16	230	21
U.S. boarding schools	***	158	43	652	89
U.S. territories & commonwealths	210	43	22	0	0
Outside the U.S.	225	86	64	565	225
<i>Totals</i>		<i>17,078</i>	<i>4,306</i>	<i>41,426</i>	<i>6,761</i>

*A total of 1,308,615 students from 18,603 schools entered the 2026 National Merit Program by taking the 2024 qualifying test and meeting participation requirements.
**The national qualifying score for Commended Students in the 2026 program is 210.
***U.S. boarding schools that enroll a substantial portion of students from outside the state in which the school is located are grouped into geographic regions; regional qualifying scores for Semifinalist standing vary from 220 to 225.

the thousands of students representing every state who have earned the Merit Scholar® title and have gone on to excel in undergraduate studies and beyond.

Second, the decision to offer the qualifying test, and to whom, belongs to officials of the individual schools. Some schools administer the PSAT/NMSQT to all juniors, while others test only a few. Therefore, although the 20,000 high schools that administer the PSAT/NMSQT enroll the vast majority of the nation's eleventh graders, the proportion of students tested in a particular year may differ markedly from school to school and state to state.

Third, while demographic changes that affect school enrollments are appreciably greater in some states and communities than in others, schools must design programs that are effective for all of their students. States and communities also differ in per capita income of residents, educational achievement of the adult population, per pupil expenditure for education, and qualifications prescribed for teachers. In addition, schools vary widely in educational objectives and standards, in numbers of seniors who plan to attend college, in curricular offerings, and in the extent to which students take advantage of the highest-level courses offered. Many factors influence student performance, and no single factor accounts for differences among educational units.

For these and other reasons, National Merit Program data provided to schools should not be used to measure the educational quality of a school, district, or state. **Qualifying scores and numbers of recognized students are relevant only within the context of a particular year's competition, and use of such data for any other purpose is neither valid nor appropriate.** NMSC regularly cautions news media, high schools, and all others interested in the competition against attempts to make comparisons on the basis of numbers of students honored in the National Merit Program. When this caution is ignored, conclusions drawn are usually erroneous and can be detrimental to the groups being compared as well as to the National Merit Program and the participating students.

Responsibilities of Semifinalists and their high schools

To compete for National Merit[®] Scholarships, Semifinalists must advance to the Finalist level of the competition by fulfilling several additional requirements. A Semifinalist can become a Finalist and compete for a Merit Scholarship[®] award in only one program year.

Requirements for Finalist standing

To qualify as a Finalist, a Semifinalist must:

1. continue to meet all requirements for participation in the competition (see pages 6–8);
2. be enrolled in the last year of high school and plan to enroll full-time in college the following fall, or be enrolled in the first year of college if grades 9 through 12 were completed in three years or less;
3. be fully endorsed for Finalist standing and recommended for a National Merit Scholarship by the high school principal (or school official designated by the principal);
4. have a record of consistently very high academic performance in all of grades 9 through 12 and in any college courses taken;
5. complete the NMSC[®] Online Scholarship Application (OSA) with all information requested;
6. take an authorized administration of the SAT[®] or ACT[®], earn scores that confirm performance on the PSAT/NMSQT[®] taken for program entry, and arrange for the National Merit Program to receive an official score report of the SAT or ACT taken; and
7. provide any additional documentation and information that NMSC requests.

In late August, NMSC sends high school principals a list of their Semifinalists, along with instructions for using the OSA. Important

information about requirements and deadlines is available both through the OSA and on NMSC's website. Both the Semifinalist and the school official must supply a substantial amount of information on the application, which NMSC uses to determine whether the student qualifies to advance to Finalist standing and to select scholarship recipients.

What Semifinalists must do

One requirement on the OSA is the submission of a personal *essay* authored solely by the Semifinalist. Semifinalists must respond to an essay prompt provided on the OSA, which helps scholarship selection committees get to know the applicants better and discern the most outstanding students. Each Semifinalist also completes a section of the application listing *activities/volunteer service, leadership positions, honors or awards, and employment*.

The OSA requires the Semifinalist to supply *biographical information* that includes home address, parental employment, college choice, college major, and career plans. This information is used to identify candidates for corporate-sponsored and college-sponsored awards provided for Finalists who meet a grantor's specified criteria. It is important for the Semifinalist to report to NMSC all changes in this biographical information that occur after the scholarship application is submitted.

In addition, each Semifinalist in the 2026 competition must make all arrangements to *take either the SAT or ACT* on one of the national administration dates specified in the scholarship application materials and to *have an official score report sent* to NMSC. To become a Finalist, the Semifinalist must *earn SAT or ACT scores that confirm the PSAT/NMSQT performance*. The scores a Semifinalist submits will only be used to determine whether Finalist requirements are met and will not be used in the selection of award recipients.

A Semifinalist who attends high school outside the United States and has not yet become a U.S. citizen must submit citizenship documentation to NMSC with the Scholarship Application. The *Requirements and Instructions* document available through the OSA and on NMSC's website provides information about the documentation needed.

What high schools must provide

For a Semifinalist to advance to Finalist standing and compete for National Merit Scholarships, the student's high school principal (or a school official designated by the principal) must *endorse* the Semifinalist for further consideration. A school official must also complete several sections of the OSA, including the Semifinalist's academic record (course work and grades), information about the school, and a school recommendation and characterization of the Semifinalist. Further, the principal is asked to notify NMSC **at once** if at any time during the competition the academic performance of a student at either the Semifinalist or Finalist level declines noticeably, or if the school can no longer recommend the student for Merit Scholarship consideration.

High schools must provide a report of the student's *academic record*, which includes grades earned and course work completed in grades 9 through 11 and a list of courses to be taken in grade 12. The academic record is crucial, both in determining whether the Semifinalist qualifies as a Finalist and in choosing Merit Scholar® awardees. To help evaluators place a student's record in perspective, the scholarship application includes questions about the school's curricular offerings and grading system. This information is important because the thousands of schools that Semifinalists attend vary widely in grading standards and practices; in the number and difficulty level of courses offered (including accelerated and honors sections of college preparatory subjects); and in the way grade point average and class rank, if any, are calculated. In selecting Merit Scholarship recipients, each candidate's academic record is scrutinized in the context of the particular school as well as compared to the records of students in other schools. Selection committees evaluate grades earned in relation to course load, difficulty level, and depth and breadth of subjects studied.

In the school's *letter of recommendation*, the school official is asked to describe qualities and attributes that distinguish the student from others. Because every Semifinalist who qualifies as a Finalist has an excellent academic record and outstanding test scores, the recommendation can be a valuable source of information about the student's demonstrated leadership and accomplishments, both in and out of school. The recommendation is most helpful when it complements

other information in the application, revealing personal characteristics that cannot be gleaned from test scores or grades. Citing the student's personal qualities with supporting examples is valuable because selection committees look for evidence of a student's motivation and ability to intelligently direct energy toward goals. For instance, if the candidate is considered to be a "leader" or is said to be "concerned for others," describe how this has been demonstrated and in what types of school or community activities. If the student is termed "creative" or "intellectually inquisitive," how has this specifically been shown? An effective characterization of the Semifinalist also points out how the student copes with challenges and describes situations that have resulted in personal or academic growth. Since the records of all students who attain Finalist standing are superior, no record "speaks for itself." Therefore, it is important to avoid generalizations. A thoughtfully and thoroughly prepared school recommendation is a vital and influential part of the student's scholarship application.

Notifying schools of the status of their Semifinalists

Currently, about 95 percent (over 15,000) of the Semifinalists in each competition qualify as Finalists. In February, NMSC notifies principals of their Semifinalists who have advanced to the Finalist level. A *Certificate of Merit*, attesting to distinguished performance in the competition, is provided for presentation to each Finalist. NMSC also directly informs Finalists (by mail and OSA) of the recognition and that they are being considered for a National Merit Scholarship. NMSC does not release the names of Finalists to the media, but schools may announce their Finalists if they choose.

Semifinalists who do not meet all Finalist requirements and standards are withdrawn from the competition. They are notified directly by NMSC at their home addresses.

National Merit® Program scholarships

Some 7,590 awards with a total value of over \$33 million are offered each year to outstanding participants in the National Merit Scholarship Program. In addition to 6,930 National Merit Scholarships that are awarded to Finalists, about 660 Special Scholarships are sponsored by business organizations for other high performers in the competition. All winners are chosen on the basis of their scholastic and extracurricular accomplishments, abilities, and potential for future academic success.

Types of awards

Three types of scholarships for undergraduate study are offered each year. National Merit® \$2500 Scholarships and college-sponsored scholarships are offered **only** to Finalists. Corporate-sponsored awards may be Merit Scholarship® awards reserved for Finalists or Special Scholarships offered to other outstanding students.

National Merit \$2500 Scholarships. The 2,500 National Merit \$2500 Scholarships offered annually are an integral part of the competition because every Finalist is considered for one and winners are chosen in every state and other selection unit. These single-payment scholarships are awarded on a state-representational basis, as in the designation of Semifinalists. This method ensures that distinguished students nationwide will be among each year's Merit Scholarship recipients.

NMSC® convenes a committee of college admission officers and high school counselors to choose the winners. Working in teams, committee members use their professional skills in evaluating the scholarship applications of all Finalists within a state or other selection unit.

Most of the one-time National Merit \$2500 Scholarships are financed by NMSC with its own funds. However, companies and business organizations that provide corporate-sponsored scholarships help underwrite National Merit \$2500 Scholarships with grants they provide to NMSC in lieu of paying administrative fees. Donations

All Finalists compete within their state or other selection unit for National Merit \$2500 Scholarships. In choosing Merit Scholarship winners, teams of professionals skilled in the process of selection carefully evaluate Finalists' scholastic and extracurricular records. The high school official's recommendation of the student often provides important insight about the candidate's personal qualities and leadership abilities.



made to NMSC's President's Fund also provide funding for National Merit \$2500 Scholarship awards.

Corporate-sponsored Scholarships. Each year about 150 corporations, company foundations, and professional associations finance approximately 1,490 scholarships for National Merit Program participants who meet both the competition standards set by NMSC and criteria specified by the sponsor. A corporate organization may provide awards for children of its employees or members, for residents of areas where the company is located, or for students planning to pursue college majors or careers the sponsor wishes to encourage. These scholarships are not subject to state-by-state distribution because only program participants who meet a sponsor's criteria can be considered for these awards. Almost all winners are chosen by NMSC's professional staff.

Of the 1,490 corporate-sponsored awards, about 830 are **National Merit Scholarships** offered to Finalists who meet sponsors' criteria. NMSC identifies Finalists who may be eligible for each sponsor's awards from information students provide on the OSA. (Some sponsor organizations also require candidates to file Entry Forms.) A corporate sponsor may offer a specific number of awards or elect to sponsor a scholarship for every eligible Finalist.

More than two-thirds of the corporate sponsors choose to complement their National Merit Scholarships with **Special Scholarships** for high-scoring program participants who meet the sponsor's criteria *but are not Finalists*. This enables a sponsor to offer a predetermined number of scholarships in each annual competition, even though the number of Finalists eligible for its awards varies from year to year.

To be considered for a Special Scholarship, students who meet a sponsor's criteria must file Entry Forms made available through the sponsor. NMSC contacts a pool of high-scoring candidates through their high schools and provides Special Scholarship Applications patterned after the National Merit Scholarship Applications completed by Semifinalists. (See pages 16–19.) About 660 outstanding students are recipients of Special Scholarships each year.

Corporate-sponsored Merit Scholarship awards and Special Scholarships are usually named for the sponsoring orga-

nization. However, the “National Merit” title is not included in the name of a Special Scholarship. Examples of a sponsor’s scholarship names are “National Merit AstraZeneca Pharmaceuticals Scholarship” and “AstraZeneca Pharmaceuticals Scholarship.”

The sponsor organization decides whether to provide **renewable** or **one-time** awards and also determines the dollar amount for its scholarships. One-time awards provide a single payment that can range from \$2,500 to \$10,000. Renewable awards, which cover up to four years of undergraduate study, provide a fixed stipend that can range from \$1,000 to \$10,000 per year and is the same for every recipient of the sponsor’s scholarships.

College-sponsored Merit Scholarship awards. About 150 four-year regionally accredited U.S. colleges and universities annually support about 3,600 National Merit Scholarships that can be used only at the respective sponsor institution. Finalists who have notified NMSC that a sponsor college is their first choice (and have not been offered another Merit Scholarship award) are referred to the sponsor college or university for consideration. College sponsor officials then select winners of awards the institution will underwrite.

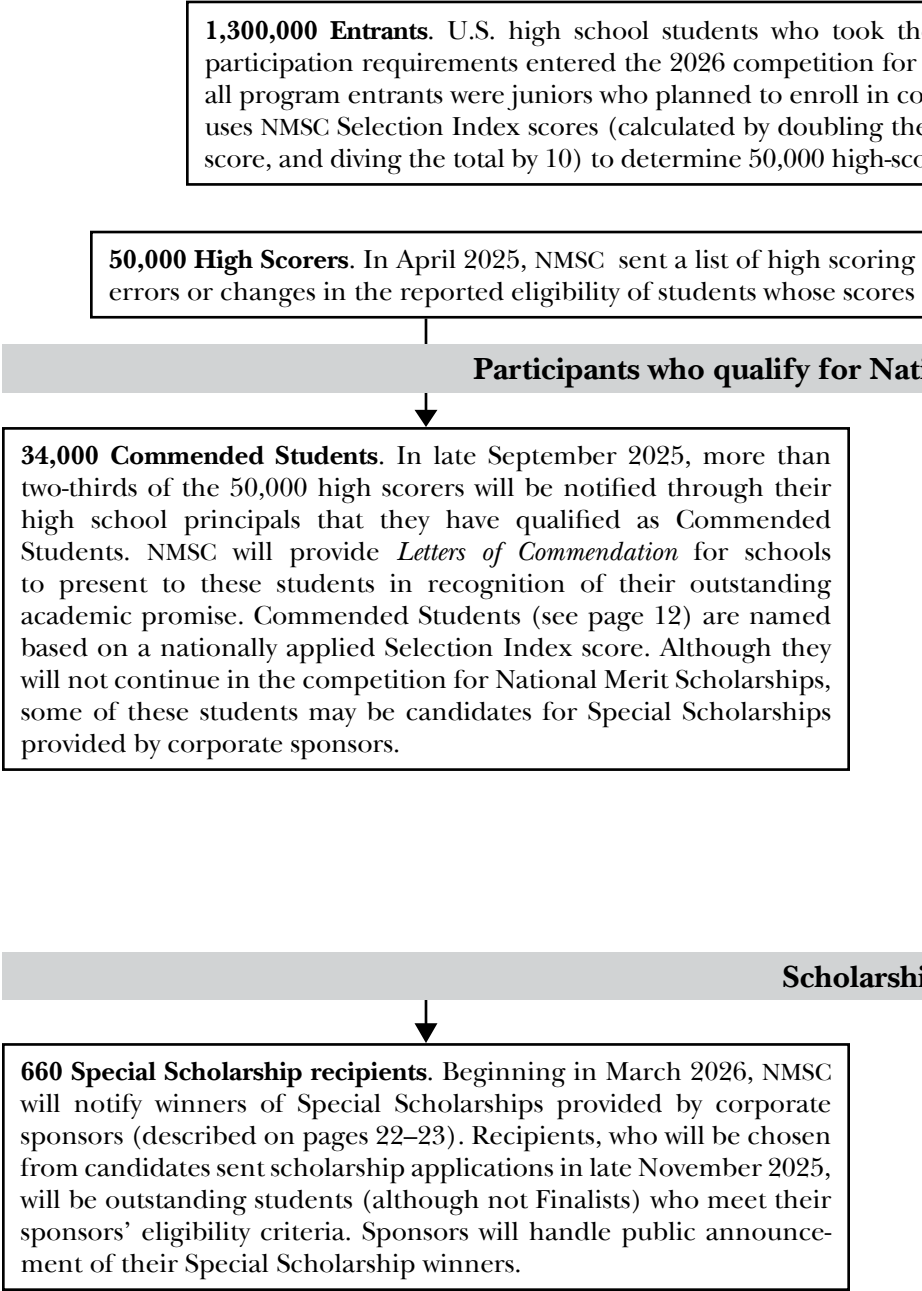
A sponsor college may decide to offer a Merit Scholarship award to every eligible Finalist who is admitted to the institution or choose to limit the number of awards it provides. A college-sponsored Merit Scholarship award is renewable for up to four years of undergraduate study at the sponsor institution. It is not transferable and is offered with the condition that it must be used at the institution financing it. For that reason, an offer is canceled if the winner decides not to attend the sponsor college or university.

Each college sponsor chooses the annual stipend their institution offers to award recipients, within a range of \$500 to \$2,000 per year. All college-sponsored scholarship recipients at the institution will receive the same stipend amount, as determined by the college.

Winner selection

Although all students who attain Finalist standing in the National Merit Scholarship Program are distinguished, unfortunately

Steps in the 2026 National M



Merit® Scholarship Program

Take the PSAT/NMSQT® in October 2024 and meet other program requirements for National Merit Program recognition and scholarships. Nearly 50,000 students will participate in the program in 2026. (See pages 6–8 for entry requirements.) NMSC® will use the Reading and Writing section score, adding the Math section score to determine the top participants who qualify for program recognition.

Participants are notified to high school principals and asked them to identify any students who qualify them for recognition in the fall of 2025.

National Merit Program recognition

16,000 Semifinalists. In early September 2025, about a third of the 50,000 high scorers will be notified that they have qualified as Semifinalists (see pages 9–12). Named on a state-representational basis, Semifinalists are the highest-scoring program participants in each state. NMSC will provide scholarship application materials explaining requirements (see pages 16–17) to advance in the competition for National Merit Scholarships to be offered in 2026.

15,000 Finalists. In February 2026, Semifinalists who meet academic and other requirements will be notified that they have advanced to Finalist standing and receive *Certificates of Merit*. All Merit Scholarship® winners (Merit Scholar® awardees) will be chosen from this group of Finalists based on their abilities, skills, and accomplishments. (See pages 23–26.)

Scholarship winners

6,930 Merit Scholarship winners. Beginning in March 2026, NMSC will notify winners of the three types of National Merit Scholarships:

- National Merit® \$2500 Scholarships
- Corporate-sponsored scholarships
- College-sponsored scholarships

During April through July, NMSC will release the names of Merit Scholar awardees to news media for publication. (See pages 20–23 and 26–27.)

not all Finalists receive a National Merit Scholarship. The National Merit Program is very competitive, and, in recent years, only about half of the 15,000 Finalists have been selected to be Merit Scholar® awardees. A student may be considered for more than one scholarship, but no student can receive more than one monetary award from NMSC.

To select winners of two types of awards, National Merit \$2500 Scholarships and corporate-sponsored awards, committees of experienced professionals evaluate a variety of information submitted about each candidate in conjunction with the scholarship application. They carefully weigh each student's academic record (including course load, difficulty level, depth and breadth of subjects studied, and grades earned) in the context of the high school's report of class size, percentage of seniors going to college, curricular offerings, and grading system. Students' essays and the recommendations of school officials may provide information about students' personal qualities, demonstrated leadership abilities, and service to their schools and communities. Winners are candidates judged to have the strongest combination of academic and extracurricular attainments and the greatest potential for success in rigorous college studies. Winners of these two types of awards are notified in March.

Recipients of college-sponsored Merit Scholarship awards are chosen by officials of the sponsor institution. College officials base their decisions on information Finalists file with the college as part of the admission process. NMSC begins sending college-sponsored Merit Scholarship offers to winners in early May.

Scholar announcements and award administration

Beginning in March, NMSC will notify scholarship winners and post formal scholarship offers to their OSA dashboards. Notification of each award will also be sent to the winner's high school. NMSC releases the names of Merit Scholarship recipients to news media nationwide in scheduled announcements (one for each type of Merit Scholarship award) on three dates in April, May, and June, followed by a second release of college-sponsored award

winners in July. (See page 48.) The announcements identify Scholars' high schools and Merit Scholarship sponsors. Special Scholarship winner announcements are handled independently by the corporate sponsors.

Every scholarship recipient is responsible for fulfilling admission requirements of the college or university to be attended. In addition, each recipient must comply with all terms specified in the NMSC scholarship offer, which cover conditions of eligibility, standards of student performance, and other requirements.

NMSC scholarship payments, which are sent to Scholars through their colleges, must be used exclusively for undergraduate education at a college or university in the United States that holds accredited status with a regional accrediting commission on higher education. NMSC scholarship stipends are not payable for students' attendance at service academies or institutions that are limited in purpose or training. Winners of one-time awards receive a single payment in the fall following their selection; four-year scholarship winners receive payments in installments, generally twice a year. To receive a scholarship payment, the winner must be enrolled full-time, be in good standing, and be pursuing a course of study leading to a traditional baccalaureate degree.

Sponsors and their support for scholarships

About 300 independent sponsor organizations and individual donors currently underwrite scholarships through the National Merit® Scholarship Program. Since the first competition in 1956, corporations and businesses have underwritten both National Merit Scholarships and Special Scholarships in every annual competition. Colleges and universities began sponsoring Merit Scholarship® awards in 1963. Individual donors also have opportunities to directly fund National Merit \$2500 Scholarship awards. The generosity of sponsors and donors is key to the success of the National Merit Program, in which scholarships worth more than \$1.8 billion have been awarded.

Sponsor support

Corporate organizations and colleges and universities have underwritten 79 percent of the 454,600 scholarships offered to date, committing a total of over \$1.6 billion. NMSC® has used over \$224 million of its own funds to support 95,000 Merit Scholarship awards.

Corporate sponsors. Over the National Merit Program's 70 competitions, business organizations have significantly increased their commitment for scholarships. In the first competition, 24 companies provided about \$800,000 to finance 195 Merit Scholarship awards and 10 Special Scholarships. In 2025, about 150 corporate sponsors committed nearly \$13 million to underwrite some 830 Merit Scholarship awards and 660 Special Scholarships. To date, corporate and business organizations have provided about 166,700 awards worth a total of more than \$924 million for program participants with qualifications of interest to the sponsor. Corporate sponsors also make a modest supplemental grant to NMSC, in lieu of paying an administrative fee, which is used to underwrite National Merit® \$2500 Scholarships that all Finalists have an opportunity to win.

College sponsors. College-sponsored Merit Scholarship awards were introduced in the eighth annual competition, when nine institutions

The 70 years of success of the National Merit Scholarship Program is largely due to the support of individual donors, corporate organizations, and higher education institutions that share the program's goals. Sponsors contribute greatly to the continued success of the National Merit Program by underwriting approximately 5,100 awards each year worth nearly \$27 million. Sponsors may hold special events to honor their award recipients.



underwrote 175 scholarships valued at approximately \$400,000. In 2025, about 150 U.S. colleges and universities committed nearly \$14 million to underwrite approximately 3,600 Merit Scholarship awards for students to attend sponsoring institutions. Over 63 competitions, colleges have expended and committed more than \$725 million for 192,900 Merit Scholarship awards. Funds from college and university sponsors are used exclusively for scholarship payments to their Merit Scholarship recipients.

Individual donors. Individuals provide support for Merit Scholarship awards through establishing endowments with NMSC or donating to NMSC's President's Fund. In 2025, some individuals made arrangements with NMSC to underwrite National Merit \$2500 Scholarship awards, and 23 scholarships were offered this year.

NMSC services for sponsors

The National Merit Program provides educationally sound and cost-effective professional services for corporations, higher education institutions, and individual donors that wish to sponsor scholarships for scholastically talented young people in whom they have particular interest.

For corporate sponsors and individual donors, NMSC:

- identifies scholarship candidates who meet a sponsor's criteria (i.e., children of company employees, residents of plant communities and areas specified by the sponsor, or students planning to pursue particular college majors and careers);
- collects information about the most outstanding candidates eligible for a sponsor's awards;
- selects scholarship recipients and determines their annual stipends;
- sends scholarship offers to award winners;
- announces Merit Scholarship winners through news media nationwide;

- provides scholarship certificates for corporate sponsors to present to their award recipients or provides certificates directly to individual donors' award recipients;
- sends scholarship payments to recipients through their colleges; and
- administers the awards and monitors winners' progress toward their undergraduate degrees.

For college sponsors, NMSC:

- identifies Finalists who wish to attend the sponsor institution and refers them to college officials for scholarship consideration;
- sends scholarship offers to award winners;
- distributes news media announcements about winners;
- provides certificates for presentation to winners;
- sends scholarship payments to winners; and
- administers the awards throughout the recipients' undergraduate years at the sponsor college or university.

Sponsor identity. The sponsor is identified with the awards it supports in several ways, including the name of the scholarship: for example, "National Merit Chevron Scholarship," "National Merit Lehigh University Scholarship," and "National Merit Gaylord and Dorothy Donnelley Memorial Scholarship." Information about the sponsor is included in NMSC media announcements about Merit Scholarship winners. Scholarship certificates identify the sponsor and are often presented at events held by sponsors to honor their award recipients.

Names of corporate scholarship sponsors and endowment scholarship sponsors with descriptions and numbers of awards offered are listed in the *PSAT/NMSQT® Student Guide*. This publication is available online to high school students before the annual competition begins in October.

National Merit Program scholarship sponsors

Each sponsor organization underwrites from 1 to nearly 200 scholarships annually. Following is a list of 334 corporate organizations, individuals, and higher education institutions that have financed scholarships awarded by NMSC during the past four academic years. Sponsors that will offer scholarships for the first time in 2026 have been added.

AbbVie Foundation

Abilene Christian

University

Acushnet Company

Adient Foundation Inc.

ADP Foundation

Aerojet Rocketdyne

Foundation

Akzo Nobel Inc.

Albany International

Ameren Corporation

Charitable Trust

American Air Liquide

Holdings, Inc

American City Business

Journals, Inc.

American Electric Power

American University

The AMETEK Foundation

Aon Foundation

Apache Corporation

Arizona State University

Arkema Inc. Foundation

Ascension

Aspen Technology, Inc.

Astellas US LLC

AstraZeneca Pharmaceuticals LP

Auburn University

BASF Corporation

Battelle

Belmont University

Bentley Systems,

Incorporated

Trust Under The Will of

Mary E. Beyerle

BNSF Railway Foundation

The Boeing Company

Boston College

Boston University

Bowdoin College

Bradley University

Brady Corporation

Brandeis University

Bridgestone Americas

Trust Fund

Brigham Young University

Bristol Myers Squibb
Foundation
Broadridge Financial
Solutions, Inc.
Brown & Brown, Inc.
Bucknell University
Bunge
Bunzl USA, LLC
CACI International Inc
Calvin University
Carleton College
Carlisle Companies
Incorporated
Carpenter Technology
Corporation
Case Western Reserve
University
CC Services, Inc.
CDK Global, LLC
Cencora, Inc.
Centre College
Chevron U.S.A. Inc.
The Child Family
Claremont McKenna
College
Clemson University
Coalfire Systems, Inc.
Colby College (Maine)
Colgate-Palmolive
Company

College of Charleston
College of Wooster
Colorado College
Colorado State
University
Commvault Systems, Inc.
Computer Aid, Inc.
Corning Incorporated
Creighton University
Crum & Forster
CSX Corporation
Davidson College
DePauw University
Dollar Tree, Inc.
Gaylord and Dorothy Donnelley
Foundation
Drake University
Eastman
Eaton Charitable Fund
ECMS
Ellucian Company L.P.
Embry-Riddle Aeronautical
University
Emerson Charitable
Trust
Emory University
The Estée Lauder
Companies Inc.
Eversource Energy
Foundation, Inc.

Federal Express Corporation	General Dynamics Ordnance and Tactical Systems
FedEx Custom Critical, Inc.	Georgia-Pacific Foundation, Inc.
FedEx Freight Corporation	Gleason Family Foundation
Ferro Corporation	Global Tungsten & Powders LLC
Fifth Third Foundation	W.W. Grainger, Inc.
Florida Atlantic University	Greyhound Lines, Inc.
Florida International University	Grinnell College
Florida State University	Gustavus Adolphus College
Fluor Foundation	Harding University
FMC Corporation	Harvey Mudd College
Fordham University	Hendrix College
Formosa Plastics Corporation, U.S.A.	Hill-Rom Holdings, Inc.
Fox News Network, LLC	Hillsdale College
FTS International, LLC	Hope College
Furman University	Hormel Foods Corporation Charitable Trust
GAF	The Hubbell Foundation
Gannett	Hunter Industries Incorporated
Gates Industrial Corporation Foundation	Illinois Tool Works Inc.
GEICO Philanthropic Foundation	Illinois Wesleyan University
General Dynamics Corporation	Indiana University Bloomington

Ingalls Shipbuilding Division
of Huntington Ingalls
Industries
Insperity Services, L.P.
Iowa State University
J. Walter Thompson Company
Fund, Inc.
JBT Marel Corporation
Johnson & Johnson
Services Inc.
Kalamazoo College
Kaman Corporation
Kansas State University
The Kennametal
Foundation
Kenyon College
L3Harris Technologies
LANXESS Corporation
Lawrence University
(Wisconsin)
Lehigh University
Leidos, Inc.
Lewis & Clark College
(Oregon)
Liberty Mutual Scholarship
Foundation
Liberty University
Loews Corporation
Louisiana State
University

Louisiana Tech
University
Loyola University
Chicago
LPL Financial LLC
The Lubrizol Foundation
Luther College
Macalester College
Mannington Mills, Inc.
Marquette University
Marsh McLennan
McGraw Hill LLC
Mead Witter
Foundation, Inc.
MH Mediate
Michigan State
University
Michigan Technological
University
Mississippi State
University
Missouri University of Science
and Technology
The MITRE Corporation
Molex LLC
Montana State University-
Bozeman
Moody's Foundation
Motorola Solutions
Foundation

National Distillers Distributors Foundation	Ohio University-Athens
Nationwide Foundation	Oklahoma Christian University
New College of Florida	Oklahoma State University
New Jersey Manufacturers Insurance Company	Old National Bancorp
New York Life Foundation	Franklin W. Olin College of Engineering
The NewMarket Foundation	Omron Foundation, Inc. onsemi
NextEra Energy Foundation, Inc.	Ouachita Baptist University
NiSource Charitable Foundation	Owens Corning Foundation
Norfolk Southern Foundation	Paramount Global
North Dakota State University	Parker Hannifin Foundation
Northeastern University (Massachusetts)	Frank E. Payne and Seba B. Payne Foundation
Northrop Grumman Corporation	Pennsylvania State University
NOV Inc.	The PepsiCo Foundation, Inc.
Novartis US Foundation	Pfizer Inc.
Novo Nordisk Inc.	Pilkington North America, Inc.
NVIDIA Corporation	Pomona College
Oberlin College	PPG Foundation
Occidental College	PPL
Occidental Petroleum Corporation	PricewaterhouseCoopers Charitable Foundation, Inc.
	Primient

Principal Life Insurance
Company
Public Service Enterprise
Group
Purdue University
Putnam Investments, LLC
Quanex Foundation
Raytheon Company
Rensselaer Polytechnic
Institute
Research Triangle
Institute
Reynolds American
Foundation
Rheem Manufacturing
Company
Rhodes College
Robert Half Inc.
Rochester Institute of
Technology
Rockwell Automation
Charitable Corporation
Rose-Hulman Institute of
Technology
RSM US LLP
Rutgers, The State University
of New Jersey
S&P Global
Saint Louis University
St. Olaf College

Samford University
Santa Clara
University
Schindler Elevator
Corporation
Schneider Electric North
America Foundation
Sensient Technologies
Foundation
Sentry Insurance
Foundation, Inc.
Siemens Foundation
Snap-on Incorporated
Sogeti USA
Sony Electronics Inc.
South Carolina Sports
Medicine and
Orthopaedic Center
Southern Company
Services, Inc.
Southern Methodist
University
C. D. Spangler
Foundation, Inc.
Specialty Materials Inc
Spirit AeroSystems, Inc.
State Farm Companies
Foundation
Stony Brook
University

Stronger Minds Foundation	United Services Automobile Association
Suburban Propane, L.P.	University of Alabama at Birmingham
Synthomer Foundation	University of Alabama in Huntsville
Teachers Insurance and Annuity Association of America	University of Alabama at Tuscaloosa
TEGNA Foundation, Inc.	University of Arizona
Tennessee Technological University	University of Arkansas, Fayetteville
Texas A&M University	University of Central Florida
Texas Christian University	University of Cincinnati
Texas Instruments Foundation	University of Dallas
Texas Tech University	University of Dayton
Textron Charitable Trust	University of Evansville
3M Company	University of Florida
The Travelers Employees' Club	University of Georgia Foundation
Tredegar Corporation	University of Houston- Main Campus
Trinity University (Texas)	University of Idaho
Truist Financial Corporation	University of Iowa
Truman State University	University of Kansas
TTEC Foundation	University of Kentucky
Tufts University	University of Louisville
Tulane University	University of Maine
	University of Maryland
	University of Miami

University of Minnesota	University of Texas at
University of Mississippi	Dallas
University of Missouri-	University of Tulsa
Columbia	University of Utah
University of Montana-	University of Wisconsin-
Missoula	Madison
University of Nebraska-	University of Wyoming
Lincoln	The UPS Foundation
University of Nevada,	USG Foundation, Inc.
Las Vegas	Valparaiso University
University of Nevada,	Vanderbilt University
Reno	Varian Medical
University of New Mexico	Systems
University of North Dakota	ViaSat, Inc.
University of North Texas	Villanova University
University of Oklahoma	Virginia Commonwealth
University of Oregon	University
University of Pittsburgh	Vulcan Materials Company
University of Puget Sound	Foundation
University of St. Thomas	Walgreen Co.
(Minnesota)	Washington and Lee
University of South	University
Carolina	Washington State
University of South Florida	University
University of Southern	Waste Management National
California	Services Inc.
University of Southern	Wayne State University
Mississippi	(Michigan)
University of Tennessee,	West Virginia University
Knoxville	Foundation, Inc.

Westlake

Wheaton College (Illinois)

Whitman College

Wichita State University

Willamette University

Wofford College

Zoetis Inc.

PSAT/NMSQT® procedures and reports

The Preliminary SAT/National Merit Scholarship Qualifying Test (PSAT/NMSQT), which is cosponsored by NMSC® and College Board, is the official route of entry to the National Merit® Scholarship Program. The PSAT/NMSQT is delivered digitally through Bluebook™, College Board's custom-built application for the test. High school officials should refer to the College Board website at <https://satsuite.collegeboard.org/k12-educators/about> for a full description of the PSAT/NMSQT and an explanation of what is included on the test. The *PSAT/NMSQT Student Guide* will be available online to all administrators and test takers in advance of the test administration. The *Student Guide* provides test-taking tips and includes information on how to take a full-length Practice Test through Bluebook. It also contains valuable information about the National Merit Scholarship Program. For the latest updates to testing policy, please see <https://satsuite.collegeboard.org/k12-educators/educator-experience>.

Note: The PSAT™ 10 and PSAT™ 8/9 will not be considered for entry to the National Merit Scholarship Program. Please contact NMSC directly with questions about entering the program.

Registration, test dates, and fees

Questions about testing arrangements should be directed to the PSAT/NMSQT office. Educators may contact the PSAT/NMSQT office toll free at (888) 477-7728, from 9:00 a.m. to 6:00 p.m. Eastern Time, Monday through Friday; educators in schools outside the U.S. may call +1(212) 237-1335. The PSAT/NMSQT office fax number is (610) 290-8979, and the email address is psathelp@info.collegeboard.org. A wide array of information is also provided on College Board's website at www.collegeboard.org.

School registration. Registration for the PSAT/NMSQT is by high school, not by individual student. A link to College Board's SAT Suite Ordering and Registration System is emailed to PSAT/NMSQT Coordinators by late April. To allow sufficient time to complete all

test-related readiness tasks, schools should place their order at least 3 weeks before their intended test administration date.

Test dates. The PSAT/NMSQT testing date window is October 1 through October 31, 2025. The official who places the order must indicate the day the school intends to administer the test within the testing window. If a school decides to change their test date from the one designated when placing their order, they can do so at their discretion as long as it is within the testing window. A designated school official will upload a registration file containing information about the students who will be testing.

Test fees. The fee for the 2025 PSAT/NMSQT is \$18.00 per student tested. Schools may charge students an additional amount to cover local administrative costs, but the total fee must be the same for all students. Some schools cover all or part of the cost for their students.

Test preparation and administration

Test center staff use Test Day Toolkit, an intuitive web-based application for educators, to administer the PSAT/NMSQT. Each staff member will need a College Board Professional Account to use Test Day Toolkit. Before the test, the test coordinator will be able to see the roster of registered students in the application. Proctors will use Test Day Toolkit to check students in, read the script, start the test, monitor student progress, and report irregularities. Test Day Toolkit also includes helpful guides and resources.

Schools are emailed information about required training modules of the procedures for administering the digital test. Training topics for coordinators and staff include test center planning, Test Day Toolkit, technology requirements, and test day procedures.

Schools are also emailed access to resources on College Board's website that supplement Test Day Toolkit. The manuals and other materials cover everything needed for administering the test, including planning, technical readiness and troubleshooting, Test Day Toolkit setup, test coordinator test day procedures, instructions for proctors and hall monitors, and flyers for students and parents.

Only the scores of students who are tested according to published policies and procedures will be considered in the National Merit Scholarship Program. NMSC reviews all Irregularity Reports and reserves the right to make decisions regarding students' participation in the National Merit Program.

Schools should complete a student readiness check with their students one to two weeks prior to when they expect to begin testing. Allow at least 30 minutes for students to complete the student readiness check, which includes answering some preliminary questions. More time should be allotted if students will be taking the practice test at that time. Students will need Bluebook installed on an acceptable device and a sign-in ticket with login credentials to access the full-length in-app practice test.

Schools should reserve at least 20 minutes on test day for students to get set up and started. This time is needed for students to view a tutorial video. Students who have not completed their student readiness check will need additional time to complete exam setup before they begin testing. Actual testing time is 2 hours and 14 minutes, plus a 10-minute break between sections. (Some students testing with accommodations may require more time.)

Answers are submitted automatically when a student's test time is up and the student's testing status in Test Day Toolkit will change to "Submitted." Proctors should make sure students get to the Congratulations page to ensure student answers have been successfully submitted. Also, any irregularities will need to be reported in Test Day Toolkit within 5 days of testing.

Special testing arrangements for individual students

For the following situations, special arrangements must be made. Arrangements for all but the last situation must be made **well before** the test administration date.

U.S. students temporarily outside the country. For students who will be studying outside the U.S. when their U.S. high schools administer the PSAT/NMSQT, testing arrangements must be made in advance. If a student wants to take the PSAT/NMSQT internationally, they should contact a local school as early as possible,

but no later than 6 weeks prior to the test. Students should visit <https://ordering.collegeboard.org/testordering/publicSearch> to look for schools in their area, and contact the school to request arrangements for testing.

Students with documented disabilities. Students with disabilities must be approved for accommodations by College Board Services for Students with Disabilities (SSD) well in advance of test day. Students who have not already been approved for accommodations must submit a request for accommodations. Your school's SSD Coordinator can submit requests for accommodations online. Requests must be submitted at least seven weeks prior to the week that testing will begin. Information about the process for requesting testing accommodations is provided on the College Board website at www.collegeboard.org/ssd. Contact the SSD office by calling (844) 255-7728.

Most accommodated students test digitally, and many accommodations are provided through Bluebook. Occasionally a student will be approved to test with a paper version of the PSAT/NMSQT. Guides for testing students with approved accommodations are available in the Test Coordinator Manual and Proctor Manual posted on the College Board website.

Students who cannot test on their school's date. If it is known in advance that one or more students cannot take the test on the day their high school will administer it, the high school may choose to offer the test on an additional test date within the testing window. If the high school has no other test dates available, the student or a school official may make arrangements for the student to test at a nearby school that has chosen another test date. For example, a school administering the PSAT/NMSQT on Saturday may arrange for a student whose religious observance prevents Saturday testing to be tested at a school giving the PSAT/NMSQT on another test date. These arrangements are possible only if another school agrees and has space available. The administering school will be responsible for uploading the student's registration data.

Homeschooled students may request to test at a local high school since the PSAT/NMSQT cannot be administered at home. NMSC en-

courages high schools to honor such requests. These students are instructed to contact the local high school as early as possible regarding registration for the test. The administering school will be responsible for registering the student, but homeschooled students' scores will not be included in testing schools' reports.

Students who miss the PSAT/NMSQT administration. A student who meets all other requirements for participation in the National Merit Program but does not take the PSAT/NMSQT because of illness, an emergency, or other extenuating circumstance may still be able to enter the competition. To request information from NMSC about alternate testing arrangements, refer to pages 8–9 for procedures and the postmark deadline date.

Online score reports

PSAT/NMSQT scores are released online to educators a few weeks after the test administration. High schools also receive a printable PDF of each student's score report. College Board will provide guidance for distributing score reports to students and connecting assessment results to instruction. Schools should go to <https://psat.org/scores> in the fall for more information about score availability for schools and their students. Schools receive summaries that provide data about their students' answers compared with other students nationwide. Resources are also available to support counselors and other educators during score release. Educators may visit the College Board website at <https://counselors.collegeboard.org/assessments/psat-nmsqt/scores> for further information. Additionally, educators can find benchmarks and further context for scores in the guide PSAT/NMSQT and PSAT 8/9: Understanding Scores for Educators at <https://psat.org/downloads>.

Students can access their PSAT/NMSQT scores online two days after their scores are released to their high school. Each student's online score report provides the student's total score, Reading and Writing section score, and Math section score; percentiles; knowledge and skills insights; examples of future career possibilities; NMSC Selection Index score and responses to eligibility questions used to determine whether the student meets

requirements for entry* to the National Merit Scholarship Program; and a link to free, tailored SAT® practice recommendations at Khan Academy. Students will also be able to access their scores through College Board's BigFuture School free mobile app.

*An asterisk printed next to a student's NMSC Selection Index score indicates that the Selection Index score will not be considered in the National Merit Scholarship Program because the student does not meet all entry requirements (outlined on pages 6–8). If the student made an error when completing the entry requirement questions on the PSAT/NMSQT or a change has occurred that may affect participation, a school official or the student may submit a request to update their answers with NMSC at www.nationalmerit.org/studentupdate. An asterisk can also indicate that a student's Selection Index score is reported for guidance-purposes only. In such a case, your school will have information from College Board about why the Selection Index score cannot be considered.

Key dates

2026 National Merit® Scholarship Program

2024

October 1 through October 31, 2024: Students entered the 2026 program by taking the 2024 Preliminary SAT/National Merit Scholarship Qualifying Test (PSAT/NMSQT®).

2025

August 26: National Merit Scholarship Application instructions for Semifinalists mailed to high school principals.

September 8: Booklet listing all 16,000 Semifinalists and this Guide mailed to high school principals and admission officials of four-year regionally accredited U.S. colleges and universities.

September 10: Date for news media nationwide to release NMSC's announcement of Semifinalists.

September 11: *Letters of Commendation* for Commended Students mailed to high school principals.

September 13: Authorized SAT® administration for Semifinalists.

October 4: Authorized SAT administration for Semifinalists.

By October 8: Schools submit completed National Merit Scholarship Applications to NMSC®.

October 18: Authorized ACT® administration for Semifinalists.

November 8: Authorized SAT administration for Semifinalists.

Late November: Application instructions for Special Scholarship candidates mailed to high school principals.

December 6: Last authorized SAT administration for Semifinalists to be considered for Finalist standing.

December 13: Last authorized ACT administration for Semifinalists to be considered for Finalist standing.

2026

February 2: *Certificates of Merit* for Finalists mailed to principals.

February 9: Notification of advancement to Finalist standing mailed to Semifinalists' home addresses. A copy of the letter will also be posted to the Finalist's Online Scholarship Application dashboard.

March 11: NMSC begins notifying winners of corporate-sponsored Merit Scholarship® awards and Special Scholarships. Each winner's high school is also notified.

March 26: NMSC begins notifying winners of National Merit® \$2500 Scholarships. Each winner's high school is also notified.

May 1: NMSC begins notifying winners of college-sponsored Merit Scholarship awards. Each winner's high school is also notified.

Mid-May: Finalists not chosen to receive a National Merit Scholarship are notified at their home addresses. Candidates not chosen as Special Scholarship winners are also notified.

National Merit Scholar press releases

April 22: Corporate-sponsored Merit Scholarship winners

May 13: National Merit \$2500 Scholarship winners

June 3: College-sponsored Merit Scholarship winners

July 13: Additional college-sponsored Merit Scholarship winners

A few additional National Merit \$2500 Scholarship winners and corporate-sponsored Merit Scholarship recipients will be announced individually during the summer.

Key dates

2027 National Merit® Scholarship Program

2025

Late April: 2025 PSAT/NMSQT® ordering information emailed to high school PSAT/NMSQT Coordinators.

August: 2025 *PSAT/NMSQT Student Guide* is available online.

By early September: Participating schools register their students for the 2025 PSAT/NMSQT.

October 1 through October 31: Testing window for the administration of the PSAT/NMSQT.

Late October through November: 2025 PSAT/NMSQT online scores are available to educators.

2026

April 1: Postmark deadline for students who missed taking the 2025 PSAT/NMSQT to request consideration for alternate entry to the 2027 National Merit Program (see pages 8–9).

Mid-April: High school principals are notified if any of their students are among the 50,000 entrants with the highest PSAT/NMSQT Selection Index scores and asked to report any errors or changes in the reported eligibility of their high scorers.

Early September: Principals are notified of their Semifinalists in the 2027 National Merit Scholarship competition.

Note: Dates for completion of the 2027 National Merit Program will be published in the September 2026 *Guide*.

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NMSC Mission Statement

The mission of National Merit Scholarship Corporation (NMSC®) is to recognize and honor the academically talented students of the United States. NMSC accomplishes its mission by conducting nationwide academic scholarship programs. The enduring goals of NMSC's scholarship programs are:

- To promote a wider and deeper respect for learning in general and for exceptionally talented individuals in particular
- To shine a spotlight on brilliant students and encourage the pursuit of academic excellence at all levels of education
- To stimulate increased support from individuals and organizations that wish to sponsor scholarships for outstanding scholastic talent

NMSC Lamp of Learning Logo

NMSC's "Lamp of Learning" logo is modeled after an oil-burning lamp—a classic symbol of knowledge and wisdom. Education fuels the flame that burns from the lamp, which is shown resting on a base that represents the Book of Knowledge. The logo is symbolic of the enduring goals of NMSC's scholarship programs.



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